

RTL Design Sherpa

GATLING-RV32ITETRAD Micro-Architecture Specification 0.1

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No waveforms in this document.

1 Gatling Mas Index

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2 Document Information

2.1 GATLING-RV32ITETRAD Micro-Architecture Specification

Document Number: GATLING-MAS-001 **Version:** 0.1 **Status:** Draft **Classification:** Open Source - MIT License

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2.2 Document Purpose

This Micro-Architecture Specification (MAS) describes how gatling, the four-context barrel RV32I, is built: the rotation that interleaves four hardware contexts through one F/D/X/W datapath, the context register files, the block-RAM memory system with one bank per context, per-context halts and run control, and how the design is verified. It is written for implementers and maintainers of the RTL and for reviewers checking it against the PRD.

The ISA and halt contract are kestrel's, and gatling uses kestrel's decode, immediate generator and ALU unchanged; their internals are in the KESTREL MAS and are not repeated here. The external contract is the companion GATLING HAS.

Companion Documents: - GATLING-RV32ITETRAD Hardware Architecture Specification (HAS) - The Barrel Model (`docs/barrel_model/barrel_model.md`) - why four contexts - KESTREL-RV32I MAS - the shared decode, immediate and ALU blocks

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2.3 References

Reference Documents

ID	Document	Description
[REF-1]	GATLING PRD v0.3 (`PRD.md`)	Requirements and owner decisions
[REF-2]	KESTREL MAS	The decode / imm_gen / ALU blocks gatling reuses
[REF-3]	RISC-V Instruction Set Manual, Volume I (`projects/components/riscv-ip/references/riscv-spec.pdf`)	ISA authority
[REF-4]	riscv-formal `rvfi.md` (`vendor/riscv-formal/docs/rvfi.md`)	RVFI retire-channel semantics

2.4 Terminology

Terminology and Definitions

Term	Definition
Context (hart)	One of four hardware threads: a PC, a register file, a halt state and a run bit
Rotation	The two-bit counter that names the context in F; D, X and W hold the three before it
Window	Four cycles: the interval between two instructions of one context
Context-lock	A halt that stops only its own context
Beat	One retired instruction on the RVFI port (tagged with its context)

2.5 Revision History

Document Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Description
0.1	2026-10-21	seang	Initial MAS: the RV32I barrel (gatling_core, gatling_regfile, gatling_mem_bram) as built; four harts on the Nexys A7. Xcell not yet built (custom-0 decodes as illegal).

Last Updated: 2026-10-21

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3 Overview

3.1 Machine organization

gatling is one RV32I datapath shared by four hardware contexts. Each context owns a PC, a 32-entry register file, a halt state (halted, cause) and a run bit; everything else – decode, immediates, ALU, branch comparator, load/store alignment – exists once.

The four contexts are interleaved through a four-stage pipeline in strict rotation. A two-bit counter, `sel_q`, names the context in F; D, X and W hold the contexts one, two and three before it. Every cycle each stage holds a different context, so a context has exactly one instruction in flight. That single fact removes every hazard a pipeline normally has to manage:

Table 1.1: Hazards the rotation removes by construction

Hazard	Why it cannot happen
Data (RAW)	A context's next instruction is in D at t+5; its previous instruction wrote its register at the end of W, t+3
Control	The branch target is written to the context's PC at the end of X, t+2; the next fetch is at t+4
Structural	Each stage is used by one context per cycle; each memory port by one stage

Each context retires one instruction per window (CPI 4); with all four running the core retires one instruction per clock.

3.2 What is reused

gatling's ISA contract is kestrel's (PRD 3): the same opcode map, the same trap/halt causes, the same CSR stub, FENCE/FENCE.I as NOPs, MRET falling through. The blocks that implement it are kestrel's, used unchanged through kestrel's own filelists: `kestrel_decode`, `kestrel_imm_gen`, `kestrel_alu` and `kestrel_pkg`. One ISA has one source; a fix to kestrel's decode is a fix to gatling's.

New for the barrel: `gatling_core` (the rotation, the per-context state and the stage registers), `gatling_regfile` (four register files in one block RAM) and `gatling_mem_bram` (one memory bank per context, the AXIL loader, per-context run and status).

3.3 Owner decisions this build implements

Table 1.2: PRD decisions realized in the RTL

Decision (PRD v0.3)	As built
Context visibility: implicit	No context-ID read; software cannot tell contexts apart
Program placement: separate	One 16 KB program/data bank per context, seen at every address
Illegal instruction: context-lock	Every halt stops only its context; the other three keep running
Scope: RV32I barrel first	Xcell (custom-0) decodes as illegal until the cell seam exists

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4 gatling_core

4.1 Purpose

The barrel core: the rotation, four PCs, per-context halt and run control, the stage registers between F, D, X and W, and the RVFI retire port. It instantiates kestrel's decode, immediate generator and ALU, and `gatling_regfile`.

4.2 Interface

Table 2.1: gatling_core ports

Port	Dir	Stage	Description
`clk`, `rst_n`	in		Clock; asynchronous-assert reset, synchronized internally (`reset_sync`, N=3)
`hart_run[3:0]`	in	all	Per context: 1 = run, 0 = hold at RESET_ADDR (kills any of its instructions in flight)
`imem_ctx`, `imem_addr`	out	F	Fetch request: context and PC
`imem_rdata`	in	D	The fetched word, one cycle after the request (registered read)
`dmem_req`, `dmem_ctx`, `dmem_addr`, `dmem_wstrb`, `dmem_wdata`	out	X	Data access; `dmem_addr` is word-aligned, strobes and data lane-rotated
`dmem_rdata`	in	W	The load word, one cycle after the request
`halted[3:0]`, `halt_cause[3:0][3:0]`	out		Per-context halt state (kestrel_pkg causes)
`rvfi_*`, `rvfi_ctx`	out	W	One retirement per cycle at most, tagged with its

Port	Dir	Stage	Description
			context; `rvfi_order` counts that context's retirements

Parameter: `RESET_ADDR` (default 0; the board and the rv32ui battery use 0x8000_0000).

4.3 The stages

Table 2.2: Work per stage

Stage	Context	Work	Registers out
F	`sel_q`	PC of the context to the instruction RAM	`d_valid`, `d_ctx`, `d_pc`
D	`d_ctx`	Fetched word decoded (kestrel_decode) and its immediate built (kestrel_imm_gen) ; register read issued with `{d_ctx, rs1}`, `{d_ctx, rs2}`; PC+imm and PC+4 formed	control bundle, `x_pc_imm`, `x_pc4`, `x_imm`, `x_insn`
X	`x_ctx`	Operands arrive from the register file; ALU, branch comparator, next PC, misalignment and halt; data access issued; the context's PC (or halt) written	`w_*`: the writeback value, load selectors, RVFI fields
W	`w_ctx`	Load word arrives, aligned and extended; register write `{w_ctx, rd}`; RVFI beat	

PC+imm and PC+4 are formed in D because both operands are known there, which keeps the adders off X; X only selects.

4.4 Per-context state

`pc_q[c]`, `halted_q[c]`, `cause_q[c]` and `order_q[c]` are the only per-context state besides the register file. `hart_run[c]` low wins every update: the PC returns to RESET_ADDR and the halt and order clear. Otherwise the X stage updates the context it holds – its PC to the next PC, or, if the instruction halts, its halt bit and cause (the PC is not advanced, as kestrel).

Validity is carried per stage (`d_valid`, `x_valid`, `w_valid`) and re-qualified by `hart_run` of the stage's context at every stage, so stopping a context kills its in-flight instruction in whichever stage holds it: no store, no PC update, no register write, no retirement.

4.5 Halts (context-lock)

The X stage raises a halt for decode's causes (ecall, ebreak, illegal – including the not-yet-built Xcell custom-0 opcode), a misaligned control-flow target (IALIGN=32) and a misaligned load or store, exactly as kestrel. The halting instruction retires as an RVFI trap beat in W – the same cycle `halted[c]` rises – with no register write and no memory access. The context's next F slot sees `halted_q[c]` and fetches nothing; the other three contexts are unaffected.

5 gatling_regfile

5.1 Purpose

The four context register files as one 128-entry array indexed `{context, register}`, with two registered read ports and one write port, in block RAM.

5.2 Interface

Table 2.3: gatling_regfile ports

Port	Dir	Description
`rs_ctx`, `rs1_addr`, `rs2_addr`	in	Read address (D stage)
`rs1_data`, `rs2_data`	out	Read data, one cycle later (X stage)
`rd_ctx`, `rd_addr`, `rd_data`, `rd_wen`	in	Write (W stage)

5.3 Structure

Two copies of the array (`regs_a`, `regs_b`), each written on every write, give two read ports over one write port; each maps to one block RAM. The read is registered, which is the latency the barrel already has between D and X, so block RAM costs no cycle.

x0 reads zero through a read-side mask: `rs*_zero_q` registers whether the address was x0 and zeroes the RAM output. kestrel instead writes x0 to zero in reset; with four contexts that would be four reset writes, and the mask also makes a never-written RAM read zero for x0 in formal, where the array starts unconstrained.

The array has no reset (SRAM rule). D and W always hold different contexts, so the barrel never reads and writes the same entry in one cycle.

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6 gatling_mem_bram

6.1 Purpose

The board's memory system: one program/data bank per context in one true-dual-port block RAM, the AXIL loader, per-context run control and per-context status registers. Derived from `kestrel_mem_bram`: the same AXIL leaves, the same load/run discipline and the same register semantics, widened to four contexts.

6.2 Memory

`MEM_WORDS` words per context (default 4096, 16 KB), indexed `{ctx, word}`. A context's bank is its whole address space – the bank index is the context, never an address bit – so four images linked at the same base (the riscv-tests link at 0x8000_0000) load side by side.

- Port A fetches: `{imem_ctx, imem_addr}` in F, the word in D.
- Port B is the core's data port while a context's load or store is in X (word in W), and the loader's otherwise. The core always wins; the loader waits a cycle (W is held off while the core owns port B).
- A store and a fetch never touch the same word on one edge: they belong to different contexts, so different banks.

6.3 Loader rules

A loader write lands only in a bank whose context is held (run = 0); a write to a running context's bank is acknowledged and dropped, as kestrel's loader drops writes while running. Reads are served any time port B is free. So one context can be reloaded and restarted while the other three run.

6.4 Register map

Table 2.4: gatling_mem_bram registers (addr[17] = 1; memory below, bank in addr[15:14])

Address	Name	Description
0x2_0000	CTRL	W: bits[3:0] run per context. R: {halted[7:4], run[3:0]}
0x2_0004	BUILD_ID	ASCII “GATL” (0x4741_544C)
0x2_0100 + 0x10*c	STATUS	{cause[7:4], halted[1], run[0]} for context c
+0x4	CYCLES	Clocks since its run was set, frozen at its halt
+0x8	INSTRET	Its retired instructions (RVFI beats, the trap beat included)
+0xC	GP	The last value it wrote to x3: the riscv-tests verdict

Status holds its values after the context is stopped and clears when its run bit rises.

7 Internal Interfaces

7.1 The memory contract: one stage of latency, no wait

Every memory the barrel touches answers exactly one stage after it is asked:

Table 3.1: Request and data stages

Memory	Request	Data	Provided by
Instruction	F	D	`gatling_mem_bram` port A
Register file	D	X	`gatling_regfile`
Data (load)	X	W	`gatling_mem_bram` port B

This is why gatling has no `mem_wait`. kestrel, single-cycle, has to stall a cycle on every block-RAM load; the barrel's stages are exactly the block RAM's latency, so nothing waits. A memory system for gatling must keep this contract on both ports, which `gatling_mem_bram` does by registering both reads and by giving the core port B unconditionally.

7.2 Run and halt between core and memory system

`gatling_mem_bram` drives `hart_run` from CTRL; the core reports `halted` and `halt_cause` per context, and the memory system latches them into STATUS. The core's own halt state clears while a context is held; the memory system's STATUS keeps the verdict until the next run, so the host can read it after stopping the context.

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8 Micro-Architecture Behavior

8.1 The rotation, cycle by cycle

```
cycle     t     t+1   t+2   t+3   t+4   t+5   t+6
F        c0    c1    c2    c3    c0    c1    c2
D             c0    c1    c2    c3    c0    c1
X                   c0    c1    c2    c3    c0
W                         c0    c1    c2    c3
```

Context c0's instruction i is fetched at t, decoded at t+1, executed at t+2 (its PC written at the end of t+2) and retired at t+3 (its register written at the end of t+3). Instruction i+1 is fetched at t+4 from the PC written two cycles earlier, and reads its registers at t+5, two cycles after the write. Consecutive retirements of one context are exactly four cycles apart; with all four running, retirements follow the rotation order, one per clock.

A context that is held or halted leaves its slot empty: the other contexts are not shifted into it, so each still retires once per window. This is measured: in DV every context's consecutive beats are checked to be four cycles apart, and on gatling_mem_bram a context's CYCLES/INSTRET is 4.000.

8.2 Taken branches cost nothing

The branch decision and target are known in X and written to the context's PC at the end of X, two cycles before that context's next fetch. There is no wrong-path fetch to cancel, so no bubble, no flush and no prediction.

8.3 Stopping and restarting a context

`hart_run[c]` low kills context c's instruction in whichever stage holds it – the stage valid is re-qualified by `hart_run` everywhere – and holds its PC at RESET_ADDR. Released, the context fetches RESET_ADDR in its next F slot with its retirement order at 0. DV stops a context at all four rotation phases (one per stage) and checks that nothing retires while it is held; a mutant that drops the qualification in W retires one leaked beat and is caught only by the stop in the W phase.

9 Verification

9.1 DV (dv/tests, make/tests.mk rails)

Table 5.1: DV

Test	What it checks
`test_gatling_regfile`	Registered read on both ports, x0 zero in every context, contexts isolated, the barrel's read-D/write-W pattern; random traffic against a model at func/full
`test_gatling_core`	Four different programs interleaved, each golden-identical; every halt kind on its own context (context-lock); Xcell custom-0 locks only its context; run control (lone context, late start, stops at all four rotation phases, restart)
`test_gatling_rv32ui`	The riscv-tests rv32ui-p battery: four different images at once, rotated so every context runs all 42 (168 runs); golden full-field diff at every level, spike lockstep at func
`test_gatling_fuzz`	kestrel's constrained-random generator; four different streams at once; golden and spike on every stream at every level (5 / 25 / 200 streams)
`test_gatling_mem_bram`	Through AXIL: the map, banks, strobes, alias; a running bank refuses writes; reload one context while another runs; STATUS/CPI; the battery loaded and run entirely over AXIL

Each context's trace is checked with kestrel's own trace checks and against kestrel's golden interpreter and spike: gatling's ISA contract is kestrel's, so its goldens are too.

Mutation (each planted bug must turn a green suite red): register writes ignoring the context fail every directed test and the battery; the W stage ignoring `hart_run` fails run control. Both mutants

first exposed weak checks – the gate battery checked only the verdict, and run control allowed one leaked beat – which were tightened before the RTL was trusted.

9.2 Formal (formal/gatling/riscv-formal)

riscv-formal observes one hart. The wrapper reports context 0's retirements and leaves contexts 1-3 free – their instructions, load data and run bits are unconstrained every cycle – with context 0 held running. All 42 checks pass. Beyond the RV32I insn checks on context 0, `reg`, `pc_fwd` and `pc_bwd` therefore prove that nothing the other contexts execute, and no way they are started or stopped, can disturb context 0's registers or PC. The rotation treats all four contexts alike, so the proof stands for each.

Depths are on context 0's retirement phase (cycle 3 mod 4): an insn check fires at one cycle and assumes a retirement there, and off-phase that assumption is unsatisfiable (sby PREUNSAT), not a vacuous pass. Non-vacuity was measured: an ADD bug fails insn_add at depth 11; register writes ignoring the context fail `reg`; context 0's PC written by other contexts fails `pc_fwd` and `liveness`.

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10 Configuration

Table 6.1: Configuration surface

Item	Where	Value
RESET_ADDR	gatling_core parameter	0 (board and battery: 0x8000_0000)
MEM_WORDS	gatling_mem_bram parameter	4096 per context (16 KB)
NUM_HARTS, HART_W	gatling_pkg localparams	4, 2 – not a free parameter: the rotation length is the stage count

Filelists (`rtl/filelists/`): `gatling_pkg.f` (pulls kestrel_pkg first), `fub/gatling_regfile.f`, `fub/gatling_mem_bram.f`, `top/gatling_core.f` (pulls kestrel's decode/imm_gen/ALU filelists), `gatling_all.f`. The root variable is `GATLING_ROOT`; `KESTREL_ROOT` must also be set.

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11 Board Result

11.1 Nexys A7-100T (2026-10-21)

Build: `projects/fpga-systems/NexysA7/riscv-ip/gatling/build-bram` (gatling_core + gatling_mem_bram + the UART-to-AXI4-Lite bridge), IMPL=explore, from `make clean-all`. Host: `make host-gatling`, the same programs as the UART-equivalence cosim.

Table 7.1: gatling on the Nexys A7-100T

Measure	Value
Clock	100 MHz, worst slack +0.152 ns
rv32ui battery	168/168: 42 images x 4 harts, four different images at once per round
CPI per hart	4.004 / 4.005 / 4.004 / 4.004
Battery throughput	0.688 IPC (68.8 MIPS): rounds wait for their longest image
Peak throughput	1 IPC, 100 MIPS (four harts of 25)
LUTs / registers	2,281 / 1,742 (whole board top)
gatling_core	1,066 LUTs, 2 RAMB18 (the register files)
gatling_mem_bram	799 LUTs, 16 block RAM tiles (4 x 16 KB)
DSPs	0

11.2 The worst path

9.4 ns, 10 logic levels: register-file block RAM output -> branch comparator / next-PC and halt logic -> the clock enable of a context's PC register. This is the X stage; F, D and W are each a fraction of it. kestrel's worst path on the same board was 11.6 ns at IMPL=explore and covered the whole instruction.

11.3 Against kestrel

kestrel runs one program at 75 MHz and CPI 1.039: 72.2 MIPS for 1,899 LUTs. gatling runs four at 100 MHz and CPI 4 each: 100 MIPS peak for 2,281 LUTs – four harts for 20% more logic, and no wait states, hazards or branch penalty to manage. A single program on gatling runs at 25 MIPS, a third of kestrel's: the barrel pays off when there are four things to do (Barrel Model, section 5).

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12 GATLING-RV32ITETRAD Hardware Architecture Specification Index

Version: 0.1 **Date:** 2026-10-21 **Purpose:** External architecture of gatling, the four-context barrel RV32I: what an integrator and a programmer see

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12.1 Document Organization

Note: All chapters linked below for automated document generation.

12.1.1 Front Matter

- Document Information

12.1.2 Chapter 1: Introduction

- What gatling Is

12.1.3 Chapter 2: Programmer's Model

- Contexts, ISA and Halts

12.1.4 Chapter 3: Interfaces

- Core Ports and the Board Memory Map

12.1.5 Chapter 4: Performance

- Throughput and Clock

12.2 Related Documentation

- **GATLING MAS** - Micro-architecture
- **The Barrel Model** - Why four contexts
- **GATLING PRD** - Requirements, the Xcell encoding table, owner decisions

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Last Updated: 2026-10-21 **Maintained By:** RTL Design Sherpa Project

13 The Barrel Model: Why Four Contexts

Version: 0.1 **Date:** 2026-10-21 **Purpose:** The study chapter behind gatling (PRD 8.1): what kestrel's single cycle costs, why cutting it into stages does not help one instruction stream, and how four interleaved streams make the cut free.

13.1 1. The cost of one cycle

kestrel executes an RV32I instruction in one clock: the program counter, the register-file read, the ALU, the data memory and the register write are one combinational path. That is the teaching point of kestrel and it is also its price. On the Nexys A7 the path that bounds the clock runs from the instruction block RAM, through the register read and the ALU add, into the data memory's address (kestrel MAS, "Board result"):

Table 1.1: kestrel's single cycle on the Nexys A7

kestrel, Nexys A7-100T	Value
Worst path at 100 MHz (IMPL=explore)	11.6 ns
Clock closed	75 MHz (+0.156 ns)
CPI	1.039 (1.00 plus a cycle per load)
Throughput	72.2 MIPS
LUTs	1,899

Every instruction pays for the longest one. A shift, an add and a load all wait the 11.6 ns that a load-address calculation needs.

13.2 2. The obvious fix, and why it does not pay for one stream

Cut the path into stages and clock it faster. Four stages – fetch, decode, execute, write back – each hold a quarter of the work, so the clock could rise toward four times kestrel's.

For one instruction stream the gain mostly evaporates. The next instruction depends on this one: its operands may be this instruction's result (a data hazard), and its address may be this instruction's branch target (a control hazard). A pipelined single-stream core needs forwarding paths, hazard detection, stall logic and branch prediction or flushes to keep the stages busy – the falcon-suite ladder above kestrel exists to teach exactly that. Without them, the simplest correct multi-cycle machine runs one instruction at a time through all four stages: a CPI of 4 at up to four times the clock, which is roughly where it started.

13.3 3. The interleave

gatling keeps the four stages and removes the dependence instead: the stages are fed from FOUR independent instruction streams, one per hardware context, taken in strict rotation.

```
cycle     t     t+1   t+2   t+3   t+4   t+5
F        c0    c1    c2    c3    c0    c1
D              c0    c1    c2    c3    c0
X                    c0    c1    c2    c3
W                          c0    c1    c2
```

Every cycle each stage holds a different context. Context c0's next instruction is fetched at t+4, after its current one has written its PC (end of X, t+2) and its register (end of W, t+3). So:

- no data hazard – a context never reads a register that an instruction of its own still in flight is about to write;
- no control hazard – a branch resolves before that context's next fetch, so there is nothing to predict and nothing to flush;
- no forwarding, no stalls, no interlocks for the base ISA.

Each context still takes four cycles per instruction (CPI 4), but four of them retire one instruction each per four cycles: the core retires one instruction per clock. The multi-cycle cut costs nothing when there are four streams to fill it – the kestrel to merlin lesson inverted: instead of pipeline stages hiding latency for one stream, contexts hide it for each other.

13.4 4. What the four stages buy in memory

Each stage is one block-RAM latency long, and that is not a coincidence the design has to work around; it is what the design uses:

Table 4.1: every memory latency is exactly one stage

Memory	Address presented	Data used
Instruction RAM	F	D
Register file (block RAM)	D	X
Data RAM (load)	X	W

kestrel has to hold the core for a cycle on every load (`mem_wait`) because its block RAM answers a cycle late. gatling has no wait signal at all.

13.5 5. What it costs

- Four PCs and four register files instead of one – the “cheap replication” (PRD 4.1). The register files are one 128-entry block RAM (two copies for two read ports), not 4,096 flops.
- One datapath: decode, immediates and ALU are kestrel’s, unchanged.
- A context is a quarter of the machine. A single program runs at a quarter of the clock rate; the barrel pays off only when there are four things to do – which, for a tetrad of four cells, is the point.

13.6 6. Measured

On the same Nexys A7-100T (gatling board README, “Board result”; MAS chapter 7):

Table 6.1: The single cycle against the barrel

	kestrel	gatling
Worst path	11.6 ns (the whole instruction)	9.4 ns (the X stage)
Clock	75 MHz	100 MHz
Programs at once	1	4
CPI per program	1.039	4.004
Peak throughput	72.2 MIPS	100 MIPS
LUTs	1,899	2,281

Four harts cost 20% more logic and run 39% more instructions per second in total, with every instruction taking the same four clocks. The clock did not rise fourfold: the X stage – register read through ALU or branch to the next PC – is still most of kestrel’s instruction, and routing is half of the worst path (52%) on this part. The remaining stages have slack to give, which is where a deeper rotation would go.

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14 KESTREL-RV32I Micro-Architecture Specification Index

Version: 0.19 **Date:** 2026-10-20 **Purpose:** Block-level micro-architecture specification for the kestrel-rv32i single-cycle RV32I core

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14.1 Document Organization

Note: All chapters linked below for automated document generation.

14.1.1 Front Matter

- Document Information

14.1.2 Chapter 1: Overview

- Design Philosophy and Machine Organization

14.1.3 Chapter 2: Functional Blocks

- kestrel_core (top)
- kestrel_decode
- kestrel_imm_gen
- kestrel_alu
- kestrel_regfile
- kestrel_mem_loader
- kestrel_mem_bram

14.1.4 Chapter 3: Internal Interfaces

- Package Types and Top-Level Wiring

14.1.5 Chapter 4: Micro-Architecture Behavior

- The Single Cycle, Step by Step
- Misaligned Data Access Halt
- Halt, IALIGN, and the System Layer
- RVFI Aggregation

14.1.6 Chapter 5: Verification Hooks

- Verification Hooks and Observability

14.1.7 Chapter 6: Configuration

- Parameters, Defines, and Filelists

14.2 Related Documentation

- **KESTREL HAS** - Hardware Architecture Specification (external view)
- **Simplified RV32I: kestrel** - Tutorial-study book this core is documented by
- **RISC-V Falcon Suite README** - Suite overview and rung ladder
- **riscv-formal rvfi.md** - Retire-channel field semantics
- **Testplans** - V&V cross-reference (six plans)

Last Updated: 2026-10-20 **Maintained By:** RTL Design Sherpa Project

15 GATLING PRD — Tetrad Compute Engine

Version: 0.3 (2026-10-21 — first RTL: the RV32I barrel, four harts on the Nexys A7; PRD 7 items 2-4 decided; Xcell deferred to the cell seam.) **Date:** 2026-10-21 **Owner decision inputs:** “Instructions” (over MMIO) for fabric handshake; mini RV per tetrad (over per-cell ALU+FSM); codename gatling (barrel machine). **Supersedes:** PRD 0.1 wording that described gatling as replacing the per-cell ALU — the ALU stays; gatling replaces the execution FSM as its driver.

15.1 1. Purpose

Give each tetrad of the compute tile a programmable engine small enough to instantiate four times per tile, powerful enough to run compiled programs over cell input data, and honest enough to teach: the barrel processor as the kestrel→merlin lesson, inverted — instead of pipeline stages hiding latency for one stream, N contexts hide the multi-cycle latency of one shared datapath.

Owner ruling 2026-10-19: gatling sequences the four ALUs of its adjacent cells. The barrel RV32I core is the programmable sequencer for its tetrad — each context runs a small program whose POP presents operands to the cell's alu-infer issue handshake and whose PUSH retires a result line; the ALU keeps its elastic valid/ready seam and tag-alignment contract unchanged. *The program is the config*. Mode bits that remain (element width, credit batch N) move to the CFG read path. Gatling is also a barrel RISC-V with custom commands (Xcell: CFG/POP/PUSH/ECTX/FLUSH/KICK/WAIT) — the program is the schedule. Gatling never originates config traffic; cell configuration arrives in-band over delta.

15.2 2. Non-goals

- Not a falcon-suite rung. No performance chase; IPC-per-context ~ 1 is the target, not a benchmark result.
- Not per-cell processors. One engine per tetrad; the four cells are the four contexts.
- No caches, no virtual memory, no interrupts/CLINT, no M/A/F. (Machine state is 4× {PC, x1..x31} + mode CSR shadow. Full stop.)
- No CSRs as a subsystem — `Zicsr` deliberately absent; config reaches the program through the Xcell `CFG` instruction.

15.3 3. ISA — RV32I + Xcell

Base RV32I exactly as kestrel implements it (same opcode map, same trap/halt contract) so the spike lockstep flow and rv32ui battery carry unchanged. The Xcell extension occupies the custom-0 opcode (`0001011`, 0x0B) — reserved space, zero collision risk with future standard extensions.

15.3.1 3.1 Xcell encoding (custom-0, opcode 0x0B)

```
 31                      15 14   12 11      7 6       0
+-------------------------+-------+---------+--------+
|        imm[31:12]       | funct3|   rd    | 0x0B   |  CFG
|        000000000000     |  000  |   rd    | 0x0B   |  POP
|        000000000000     |  001  |  rs1    | 0x0B   |  PUSH
|        000000000000     |  010  |  00000  | 0x0B   |  ECTX
|        000000000000     |  011  |  rs1    | 0x0B   |  FLUSH
|        000000000000     |  100  |  rs1    | 0x0B   |  KICK
|        000000000000     |  101  |  rs1    | 0x0B   |  WAIT
+-------------------------+-------+---------+--------+
funct3 110/111 : reserved.
funct3 010 (ECTX) and 011/100/101 (FLUSH/KICK/WAIT) added in v0.2.
The v0.1 WAITCD/WAITGT placeholders are superseded by KICK/WAIT
pending
the tetrad MAS.
```

Instr	Action	Blocking behavior
`CFG rd, imm`	rd ← mode-register[imm]: 0=element mode (0=bf16: 2 bf16 lanes per 32-bit line, fp32 accumulate; other values reserved for the int8/fp32 roadmap per alu-infer PRD `func_sel[8:7]`), 1=credit batch N, 2=context ID (read-only, see §7 open item), 3+=reserved	never blocks
`POP rd`	rd ← next element of this context's input memory; head advances; consumed-line credit returned to rapids per credit-batch config	context stalls if input empty — hardware interlock, not a spin

Instr	Action	Blocking behavior
`PUSH rs1`	rs1 → this context's result memory; tail advances; grant requested on result path; packetizer batches X flits	context stalls if no grant
`ECTX`	context done: freeze PC, raise done status to tetrad MonBus, release datapath share; context restarts on reset/config reload	drains at next context boundary
`FLUSH rs1`	rs1[14:0] → cell `FLUSH_DEST` {ext,level,X,Y,Z}; rs1[18:15] → cell `FLUSH_TAG` (RAPIDS sink-channel tag); trigger cell flush-and-send of result memory	context stalls until drain controller accepts command
`KICK rs1`	raise tetrad coordination event on the tetrad MonBus with value `rs1`; provisional encoding pending tetrad MAS	non-blocking once event is posted
`WAIT rs1`	stall context until the tetrad coordination condition in `rs1` is observed (e.g. group-done bitmask); provisional encoding pending tetrad MAS	context stalls until condition true

Design note (owner doctrine): fixed hardware owns the line-rate handshake (credit/grant detection, memory ports); the program owns policy. POP/PUSH blocking interlocks subsume most waiting — a context that would wait simply isn't scheduled. WAIT is an explicit escape hatch for cross-context coordination, not the common case.

Element semantics: with element width < 32, POP zero-extends into rd and PUSH takes the low bits of rs1; packing/unpacking is the program's business (one ANDI/SLTI pair, honest and visible).

15.3.2 3.2 Assembly mnemonics

`gatling_pop`, `gatling_push`, `gatling_cfg`, `gatling_ectx`, `gatling_flush`, `gatling_kick`, `gatling_wait` as canonical toolchain names; assembler aliases `pop/push/cfg/ectx/flush/kick/wait` live in the Xcell binutils fragment when the flow arrives (§8).

15.4 4. Barrel microarchitecture

15.4.1 4.1 The model

Kestrel's single cycle is PC + regfile-read + ALU + memory in one combinational path — the teaching point and the timing/area cost. Gatling splits that into a 4-state FSM:

```
F  : address = ctx[sel].pc; fetch word from ctx program image
D  : decode; read ctx[sel] regfile (rs1/rs2 by decoded index)
X  : ALU / Xcell unit (POP/PUSH/CFG execute here; interlock check)
W  : writeback to ctx[sel] regfile; pc advance (or branch target)
```

Each FSM state advances context `sel` one step; `sel` rotates 0→1→2→3→0. Steady state: every context retires one instruction per 4-cycle window ⇒ 1 IPC per context, one gatling ALU, one decoder, one Xcell unit, **four** register files + PCs (the cheap replication) — replacing the cell PRD's four execution FSMs while each cell keeps its own bf16 ALU datapath (owner ruling 2026-10-19).

15.4.2 4.2 Structural hazards (all resolved by rotation, by construction)

- ALU/decoder/memory-port conflict: impossible — one user per state.
- Input/result memory port conflict across contexts: impossible — each context owns its cell's memories, addressed by `sel`.
- Interlock stall (POP empty / PUSH no-grant): only `sel` stalls; rotation skips it (bubble) — three contexts keep the datapath busy.

15.4.3 4.3 Branch behavior

Resolved in X (kestrel semantics carry: the branch decision is one comparison) and written to the context's PC at the end of X, two cycles before that context's next fetch. As built (2026-10-21) a taken branch therefore costs nothing – no bubble, no flush machinery, no BTB, no prediction. The predictor study belongs to peregrine, not here.

15.4.4 4.4 Halt/trap

No traps (no exceptions in base scope; illegal instruction → context-local lock with status bit via MonBus, other contexts continue — a tetrad is not a CPU, one bad cell must not sink the tile). `ECTX` is the normal exit. Reset is per-tile from the tile root; program load via the fabric config path (PKT_CONFIG) into each cell's program image region — kestrel's `mem_loader`/AXIL pattern becomes the in-band loader, per the standing in-band-only fabric decision.

15.5 5. Contract fit (cell PRD 0.1, unchanged interfaces)

Cell PRD block	Stand / change
delta_mesh_cell node, containment	stands — gatling sits behind the node's local port
Input memory, line fill by node from rapids	stands; per-context, addressed by `sel`
Result memory, X-flit batching, packetizer, grants	stands
Consumed-line credits to rapids, batch N (default 1)	stands; N read via CFG
Element widths B4/8/16/32	superseded — alu-infer's bf16 element model (2 bf16 lanes per 32-bit line, fp32 accumulate) is normative; CFG[0] reports the alu-infer element mode (bf16 today; int8/fp32 modes are a roadmap item in the alu-infer PRD via `func_sel[8:7]`)
ALU + execution FSM (config-selected fn)	**replaced by gatling as the execution FSM driver** — the cell's bf16 ALU datapath remains; gatling issues it via POP/PUSH and the alu-infer elastic valid/ready seam (owner ruling 2026-10-19)
MonBus observation (per-cell → per-tetrad merge)	stands; gatling adds per-context status (active/stall-reason/done) to the observed set

Consequences that must not fork: credit counting is in *elements consumed* (POP), not instructions; grants are in *elements pushed* (PUSH), not flits — flit batching stays inside the packetizer.

15.6 6. Verification

- **Base ISA:** spike lockstep on RV32I exactly as kestrel does it — reuse the rds-dv flow; rv32ui battery is the gate (42/42 precedent).
- **Xcell unit:** directed cocotb — POP empty-stall / credit batch N=1,2,4; PUSH grant/backpressure; CFG read of mode shadow; ECTX done/observability; element-width zero-extend and slice.
- **Barrel properties:** cocotb assertions — one retirement per context per rotation window; stall of context k never stalls j≠k; rotation fairness (round-robin, no starvation with all-runnable).
- **Tetrad integration:** the eventual `tetrad.sv` TB drives four input-memory streams, checks per-context result memories and the credit/grant ledger against the cell PRD reference model.
- **Formal (where it pays):** deadlock freedom of the interlock (POP-empty ∨ PUSH-no-grant ∧ no ECTX ⇒ eventually credit ∨ grant), following the repo's targeted-formal doctrine.

15.7 7. Open items (owner decisions needed)

1. **ALU-infer relationship:** RESOLVED 2026-10-19 — gatling is the programmable sequencer for the tetrad's four bf16 ALUs; each context runs a small program whose POP presents operands to the cell's alu-infer issue handshake and whose PUSH retires a result line; the ALU keeps its elastic valid/ready seam and tag-alignment contract unchanged. The v0.1 wording that made gatling "the ALU
   - execution FSM" is superseded.
2. **Context visibility:** RESOLVED 2026-10-21 (owner) — implicit. Software cannot tell the contexts apart; binaries are uniform. CFG[2] stays reserved.
3. **Program image placement:** RESOLVED 2026-10-21 (owner) — separate. Each context has its own program/data region (gatling_mem_bram: one 16 KB bank per context, seen at every address); the cell's POP input memory is separate and arrives with Xcell.
4. **Illegal-instruction policy:** RESOLVED 2026-10-21 (owner) — context-lock. Any halt (ecall, ebreak, illegal, misaligned target or access) locks only its context; the other three keep running.
5. **Xcell binutils/toolchain:** hand-assembled hex for bring-up; gcc/binutils fragment later. Non-blocking.

Resolved/added in v0.2: the FLUSH/KICK/WAIT Xcell encodings of §3.1 (answer TILE_SPEC §11.14 and the alu-infer PRD §5 tetrad-coordination pair). Their exact field layouts and MonBus integration remain provisional pending the tetrad MAS.

Scope of the first RTL (owner, 2026-10-21): the RV32I barrel first – four harts running the rv32ui battery on the Nexys A7 – with the Xcell custom-0 opcode decoding as illegal (context-lock) until the cell seam exists. Xcell lands in the next pass.

15.8 8. Deliverables & sequencing

1. `docs/barrel_model/` study chapter (kestrel cost → interleave fix) — writes first, it is the justification.
2. `gatling_has` + ISA appendix (Xcell table as authority).
3. RTL: fubs (kestrel-derived) → `gatling_top` barrel + Xcell unit → flists; unit TBs per fub on repo rails.
4. Spike lockstep bring-up of the RV32I subset; then Xcell directeds.
5. Tetrad integration when `tetrad.sv` lands in `tile/`.

15.9 9. History

- 2026-10-21: PRD 0.3. First RTL (gatling_core, gatling_regfile, gatling_mem_bram): the RV32I barrel with kestrel's decode/imm_gen/ALU unchanged, every memory a one-stage block-RAM latency, no wait signal; four harts on the Nexys A7. Owner decisions: PRD 7 items 2-4 (implicit context, separate program regions, context-lock); RV32I barrel before Xcell. 4.3 corrected: a taken branch costs no bubble.
- 2026-10-19: PRD 0.2. Owner ruling: gatling sequences the four ALUs of its adjacent cells — the barrel core is the programmable sequencer for the tetrad, the cell's bf16 ALU remains the datapath, and gatling never originates config traffic. Added FLUSH/KICK/WAIT Xcell encodings; fixed POP to read `rd`; updated CFG[0] to report the alu-infer element mode.
- 2026-10-17: PRD 0.1 scaffold. Owner decisions: instructions over MMIO; mini RV per tetrad; codename gatling; four contexts = four cells; blocking POP/PUSH interlock; ECTX exit. Cell PRD 0.1 contracts confirmed unchanged outside the replaced ALU/FSM block.